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Why Max Verstappen gave me my marching orders from a press conference | Giles Richards

In the grand scheme of things I enjoy a remarkably privileged career, paid to cover Formula One, a sport I have loved since 1976. So I am loth to complain, but was deeply disappointed when [Max Verstappen](#) chose to eject me from his press conference on Thursday at the Japanese Grand Prix over a question asked at the end of last season.

Our first face-to-face in 2026 came at Suzuka when it turned out the Dutchman had a positively elephantine recollection. When he saw me he stared, smiled and declared he would not speak until I left. In the course of a brief 30-second exchange, he told me to "get out". I have never been asked to leave a press conference. It is an extremely rare occurrence for a journalist in F1, with barely anyone able to recall more than one or two examples.

In more than a decade of covering the sport I have interviewed Verstappen perhaps a dozen times, all of them friendly and good humoured. His outstanding talent garnered praise and admiration in those articles, criticism by contrast has been minimal and only when warranted.

One incident last year, however, has seemingly touched a nerve. [At the Spanish Grand Prix](#) Verstappen drove into [the side of George Russell's car](#), for which he was punished with a 10-second penalty. It dropped him from fifth to 10th and cost him nine points. By the end of the season, after an extraordinary resurgence (heartily praised by me) and some good fortune as McLaren dropped points in the final races, Verstappen missed out on retaining his title by two points.

After the season finale in Abu Dhabi I asked him how he felt about that incident and whether he had any regrets, a question that had to be asked. Verstappen took umbrage. "You forget all the other stuff that happened in my season. The only thing you mention is Barcelona. I knew that would come. You're giving me a stupid grin now."

I'm not sure I had a stupid grin. I was certainly taken aback by the vehemence of his reply and it might have prompted a nervous smile. But I did not think it was funny, nor was I enjoying myself at his expense.

And so, on to the press conference in Japan. After being told he would not speak unless I left, I asked if it was because of the question in Abu Dhabi. He said it was. Once more I was taken aback. I might have had a nervous grin again, who knows? I asked him to confirm if it was because of the question in Abu Dhabi about Spain. He did. "You're really that upset about it?" I asked, to which he replied: "Get out. Yeah. Get out."

Marching orders received I duly departed. Verstappen had been smiling throughout the exchange. Perhaps he was simply enjoying the power dynamic? The day carried on; there are far more serious problems in the world than an F1 driver being cross with you.

Within two hours someone had tracked down my email. "You're the problem. You're the toxic dipshit who's responsible for the whole British bias in F1. You're the worst," it read. As abuse goes at least the apostrophes were in the correct places and it was not written in green crayon. I have not looked at X and have no plans to do so.

Colleagues in the press pack were universally shocked and offered concern for my wellbeing. "Classless," said one with arch disdain over Verstappen's behaviour. My wellbeing is fine. If anything, the most uncomfortable part is writing about it in the first person. A journalist never wants to be the story, even if it feels unavoidable now.

The incident and fallout are a shame nonetheless. Not least for the accusations of bias. Over the years I've been accused of anti-Lewis Hamilton, anti-Sebastian Vettel, anti-you-name-the-driver bias. Reporting as honestly and fairly as possible is always the single overarching aim.

I still admire Verstappen and I hope we can enjoy a better relationship in the future. Sometimes, difficult, awkward questions have to be asked. That's the job that comes with the privilege.

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